PRACTICAL LAWS OF PESAH

The Seder Night

Practical Laws of Pesah

With Rabbi Daniel Kada

From Kaddesh to Nirtzah — Everything You Need to Know

The Seder Plate

The Three Matzot

Why three? Not because of Kohen, Levi, Yisrael (that's a nice addition but not the real reason).

The real reason: We have **two matzot** for lechem mishneh (double bread — as on every Shabbat and Yom Tov) plus **one extra matzah** for Yachatz (breaking). That's it.

The Zero'a (Shank Bone)

Represents the **Korban Pesach** (Paschal lamb). We use a shank bone because the pasuk says Hashem took us out "bi-zero'a netuyah" (with an outstretched arm). In essence, any piece of meat would work — the shank bone is just symbolic of this pasuk.

The Beitzah (Egg)

Represents the **Korban Chagigah** (festive sacrifice brought on every Chag — on Pesach we had both the Chagigah and the Paschal lamb). We use an egg because we can't use a second piece of meat (already used for zero'a), and the egg carries a tinge of **avelut (mourning)** — reminding us we don't have the Beit HaMikdash. The roundness of the egg is always associated with mourning.

Calendar connection: Tish'ah Be-Av always falls on the same day of the week as the first night of Pesach. This year: Friday night / Shabbat (postponed to Sunday).

Karpas

Any vegetable. Sephardim: typically parsley or celery. Ashkenazim: often potato (access issue in Europe historically). Any vegetable suffices.

Maror and Chazeret

Sephardim: lettuce for both. Ashkenazim: lettuce for one, horseradish for the other.

Charoset

Reminds us of the mortar and servitude in Egypt.

This Year's Timing: First and Second Nights

First Night (Friday Night)

Le-chatchila: Begin at nightfall (~8:50 PM in London).

If necessary (young children, difficulty waiting): May begin from **sunset** (~8:00 PM), provided **Maggid does not begin before nightfall**.

Why? The only mitzvot that are biblically mandated at night are eating matzah and relating the Exodus (sippur yetzi'at Mitzrayim). All other Seder mitzvot (leaning, four cups, maror, etc.) are rabbinic — and rabbinic mitzvot may be performed from sunset if necessary.

Second Night (Motzaei Shabbat)

Must begin at nightfall (~8:52 PM). Cannot begin early because Kiddush on the second night includes **Havdalah with a candle** — which cannot be done before Shabbat ends.

However: From **sunset** (~8:00 PM), you may **set the table** — lay out cutlery, crockery, Seder plate — without doing any melachah (no heating food, no carrying fire, etc.).

Why is this permitted? The principle: issur de-rabbanan bein ha-shmashot le-tzorech mitzvah mutar — a rabbinic prohibition (preparing from Shabbat to Yom Tov) during twilight for the purpose of a mitzvah is permitted.

Ashkenazim: The Mishnah Berurah is doubtful whether this applies from Shabbat into Motzaei Shabbat (as opposed to Friday into Shabbat). Sephardim definitely hold it applies in both directions.

Kaddesh — The First Cup

The Four Cups

Why four? Either because of the four expressions of redemption in Parashat Va'era, or because of the four exiles we have survived.

Wine vs. Grape Juice

Grape juice has the same halachic status as wine. There is a preference for non-mevushal wine — but if you're not particular about this during the rest of the year (regular Friday night Kiddush), there's no reason to be particular about it specifically on Pesach.

Red Wine

The wine/grape juice should be **red** — representing the blood (dam) and the richness/nobility of the color.

Everyone Must Drink

Unlike regular Shabbat/Yom Tov Kiddush (where one person can drink for everyone), on Pesach night **every person must drink** their own cup. One person cannot experience freedom (herut) on behalf of another.

How Much to Drink

When	Amount Required
Regular Friday night Kiddush	Melo lugmav (cheekful) = ~44 ml
Each of the four cups on Pesach	A revi'it = ~86–90 ml

Reference: A standard small plastic cup is ~170–180 ml. A revi'it is about half of that.

Important: It is written that it's good to drink the majority of the cup, but strictly the revi'it suffices. Don't use tiny cups (less than 86 ml). And don't use huge cups and only sip from them — drink the full revi'it.

Drink in one or two gulps — don't sip slowly over time.

Brachot on the Four Cups (Sephardim vs. Ashkenazim)

Cup	Sephardim	Ashkenazim
1st cup	Borei Pri HaGafen ✅ (have in mind the 2nd cup too)	Borei Pri HaGafen ✅
2nd cup	No bracha	Borei Pri HaGafen ✅
3rd cup	Borei Pri HaGafen ✅ (have in mind the 4th cup too)	Borei Pri HaGafen ✅
4th cup	No bracha	Borei Pri HaGafen ✅

Shehecheyanu

When saying Shehecheyanu in Kiddush, have in mind **all the mitzvot of the night**: eating matzah, eating maror, relating the Exodus — not just the Chag itself.

Other Details

- Nice custom: one person pours for his neighbor (not strictly required).
- **No need to wash the cup between cups.** Can pour the next cup directly into leftover wine/juice. This is what Chacham Ovadia himself did. (According to Kabbalah — yes, wash inside and outside. According to halacha — not necessary.)

Children and the Four Cups

The Gemara teaches that children (even those who've reached the age of chinuch) are **not required** to drink the four cups. Of course we give them cups — it's part of the excitement. But Chacham Ovadia makes an important point: if money is tight, **spend on treats and entertainment for the children** rather than on four cups of grape juice for each child. The essence of the night is "Ve-higadeta le-vincha" — telling your children. Engaging them is more important than their drinking.

Prepare in advance: Treats, rewards, games, activities to keep children engaged and participating throughout the evening.

Urchatz — Washing Hands

Sephardi reason: This is the **year-round halacha** (Shulchan Aruch). Anytime one dips a vegetable into one of the seven liquids (including water), one must wash hands without a bracha. We do this every time, not just on Pesach.

Ashkenazi reason: To arouse the curiosity of children (since Ashkenazim don't hold of the year-round obligation to wash for dipping).

Between Urchatz and Karpas: One may speak — as long as it's relevant and there's no complete break between washing and eating.

Karpas — Dipping the Vegetable

The Main Reason

To remind us of the **tears** of Am Yisrael in Egypt. We dip the vegetable in salt water (or lemon water) and ingest it — internalizing the tears and suffering.

A Secondary Reason

This is the way of **nobility** — having hors d'oeuvres before the main meal, opening the appetite.

Leaning for Karpas?

Reason	Lean?
Tears / servitude (main reason)	❌ No — not a moment of freedom
Nobility / hors d'oeuvres (secondary)	✅ Yes

In practice: We do **not** lean for Karpas (following the main reason). Some take two pieces — one without leaning, one with — to cover both opinions.

The Bracha and How Much to Eat

Say **Borei Pri Ha-Adamah**. This bracha is intended to last all the way through until **Maror** (covering the lettuce eaten then).

Therefore: **Eat less than a ke-zayit** (less than ~18 grams) — a small taste. If you eat a ke-zayit or more, technically you'd need an after-bracha, which would "close" the Borei Pri Ha-Adamah and it wouldn't cover the Maror.

If you accidentally ate a lot: Still don't say an after-bracha.

The main point of Karpas is the dipping — not the eating. Take a small piece, dip it, eat it.

If you don't have parsley or celery: Any vegetable works. Don't stress about finding specific vegetables.

Eating during Maggid: Strictly speaking, if necessary, it is permissible to eat during Maggid.

Yachatz — Breaking the Middle Matzah

Why break it? We're about to say "Ha Lachma Anya" — this is the bread of affliction — and we say the Haggadah upon **broken bread**.

Why the middle and not the top? We keep the top matzah complete for the bracha of HaMotzi later. This way we have both: a complete matzah for the bracha and a broken matzah for the Haggadah.

The pieces: The bigger piece is set aside for **Afikoman**. The smaller piece goes back under the top matzah.

Why set aside Afikoman now? So we don't forget and eat all the matzah during the meal, leaving nothing for the required matzah at the end.

Syrian/Iraqi custom: Break the matzah into the shape of a Vav and a Dalet.

The "Stealing" of the Afikoman

Based on the Rambam's word "Hotfin" (snatch). The simple reading: snatch it away to ensure it's preserved until the end. Some turned this into a game of stealing and ransom — but this is **not the Sephardi minhag** and is questionable educationally (teaching children to steal mitzvot and hold them for ransom).

Syrian/Iraqi custom: Each person, from oldest to youngest, puts the matzah on their shoulder and asks/answers questions: "Where are you coming from? Where are you going? What do you have?" — done in Arabic traditionally.

Maggid — Telling the Story

What Makes This Night Different from Every Other Night?

We remember the Exodus **every night** (in the Shema). So what's special about Pesach night?

Two key differences:

1. **Question and answer format.** During the year, we simply state we left Egypt. On Pesach, it must be done through questions and answers — demonstrating **mental/intellectual freedom**. Paroh's ultimate goal was to suppress our ability to think independently ("Tichbad aleihem ha-avodah"). Asking questions is the greatest expression of intellectual freedom.
2. **Experiential.** "Be-chol dor va-dor chayav adam lir'ot et atzmo" — you must feel as if you yourself left Egypt. It's not historical recollection — it's personal experience.

Even a person alone asks Mah Nishtanah — because the act of questioning itself is the demonstration of freedom, regardless of whether anyone answers.

Maggid Is NOT a Prayer

There is **no value** in reading the Haggadah without understanding. Unlike prayer (where standing before the Shechinah has intrinsic value even without comprehension), Maggid is a discussion. The Haggadah is a **springboard** — not a set text to be read word for word.

No bracha on Maggid: Because the mitzvah has no defined endpoint — the entire night is available for discussing the Exodus.

What Language?

The main sections should be in Hebrew. **Everything else can and should be said in English** (or your vernacular) if that enables understanding and discussion.

The Essential Sections of Maggid

If time is limited, these are the absolute minimum:

Section	Why Essential
Mah Nishtanah	The questions — core of the night's format
Avadim Hayinu	The answer — we were slaves, now we're free
Rabban Gamliel Hayah Omer (Pesach, Matzah, Maror)	Halachic requirement — must mention these three things
Hallel and brachot at the end (Halleluyah + Asher Ge'alanu)	Prayer and praise — in Hebrew

If there's more time: Add Mitechilah (our history) and Be-chol Dor va-Dor.

Maggid doesn't end at Maggid. The entire evening — during the meal, after — is open for discussion about the Exodus.

Rachtzah — Washing for Matzah

Wash hands with a bracha — exactly as for bread throughout the year. Nothing special.

Motzi Matzah — Eating the Matzah

The Procedure

1. Take **all three matzot** in hand.
2. Say **HaMotzi Lechem Min Ha-Aretz** on the two complete matzot (top + bottom) — fulfilling lechem mishneh.
3. Put down the bottom matzah. Hold top + broken middle.
4. Say **Al Achilat Matzah**.
5. Eat a ke-zayit from the top matzah and a ke-zayit from the middle (broken) matzah.

Why two ke-zeitim? Debate whether Al Achilat Matzah applies to the complete matzah or the broken one. We eat from both to cover both opinions.

This only applies to the person leading the Seder. Everyone else needs only **one ke-zayit**.

How Much Is a Ke-zayit?

Standard	Amount
Recommended	27 grams
Sufficient (room to be lenient)	18 grams
Two ke-zeitim (for the leader)	18 + 18 = 36 grams suffices

Timeframe: Eat the ke-zayit within **4.5 to 9 minutes** (preferably under 5 minutes).

Leaning

Must lean while eating the matzah.

Not Speaking

Critical: From the bracha of HaMotzi and Al Achilat Matzah until the end of Korech — **do not speak** about unrelated matters. This bracha covers the matzah in Korech too.

Speaking about immediate needs (pass the salt, is this enough matzah, etc.) is fine. Unrelated conversation should be avoided.

Note: Between Rachtzah (washing) and HaMotzi — strictly speaking one *may* speak (same as during the year). But from HaMotzi onward through Korech — that's where silence matters most.

The Biblical Mitzvah

Eating matzah is the **second biblical mitzvah** of the night (after sippur yetzi'at Mitzrayim). The absolute bare minimum for the night: Kiddush + briefly telling the story to your child + eating a ke-zayit of matzah.

Maror — The Bitter Herb

Why Maror?

To remember the bitterness of slavery in Egypt.

Important: Maror today is only a **rabbinic** obligation. The Torah links maror to the Korban Pesach — without the Korban Pesach, maror is not biblically required. We eat it rabbinically to remember.

How Much?

One ke-zayit (~18–27 grams).

Dipping in Charoset

The halacha uses the word "lishko'a" — submerge the maror into the charoset (to remember the mortar and hard labor).

But then — shake it off. You must retain the taste of bitterness. If you leave the charoset on, you lose the maror taste entirely.

Common mistake: People submerge and eat with all the charoset. That's actually the halacha for **Korech** (see below) — not for Maror itself.

Leaning?

Do not lean for Maror. It represents bitterness and suffering — not freedom.

Korech — The Sandwich

Why?

Hillel held that matzah and maror must be eaten together. The halacha doesn't follow Hillel — but we do Korech as a **zecher (remembrance)** of his opinion.

Since we've already fulfilled the mitzvot of matzah and maror separately, Korech is an extra — not strictly obligatory.

Charoset in Korech

Here — unlike for Maror — you **may submerge** the maror in charoset and **do not need to shake it off**. Since the mitzvot are already fulfilled, enjoy it.

This is where the common confusion comes from: People think you keep the charoset on for Maror. No — for Maror, shake it off. For Korech, enjoy it.

Shulchan Orech — The Meal

Enjoy the meal.

The Egg

Different customs about when to eat the hard-boiled egg: beginning of the meal, end of the meal, some even before Maggid. **It makes no difference.** Follow your family's custom. If you don't have one, eat it during the meal.

Syrian custom: Eat the egg at the end of the meal, before Birkat HaMazon.

Can you eat from the Seder plate? Halachically yes — the purpose of the Seder plate was originally to eat from. The Arizal (Kabbalistically) said not to. But halachically, taking the egg from the plate is fine.

Tzafun — Afikoman

Why Another Piece of Matzah?

This is the **third** matzah eating of the night. It is rabbinically required to **remember the Korban Pesach** — which would have been eaten at the end of the meal.

One ke-zayit suffices.

Deadline: Before Midnight

The Korban Pesach was eaten before midnight → Afikoman should be eaten before midnight.

This year: Midnight = 1:01 AM. If you want to spend hours discussing Egypt — do it after Afikoman, not before.

Leaning

Must lean for Afikoman.

No Eating After Afikoman

To maintain the **taste of matzah** in your mouth until morning — as an expression of love for the mitzvah.

Permitted after Afikoman: Tea, coffee, water.

Not permitted: Food, dessert. Serve dessert **before** Afikoman.

Practical tip: Have your meal → dessert → Afikoman → Birkat HaMazon.

Barech — Birkat HaMazon

Don't forget: Birkat HaMazon is a **mitzvah from the Torah** — as important as eating matzah. Give it proper attention.

The Third Cup

Say **Borei Pri HaGafen** (this bracha covers the 4th cup too — Sephardim).

Hallel — Praise

Pour the fourth cup. Say Hallel.

Say it together in unison — sing it, not rush through it individually. This is **prayer and praise** to Hashem (unlike Maggid which is storytelling/discussion).

Drink the fourth cup.

Nirtzah — Songs

Why End with Songs Like Echad Mi Yodea?

A psychological/spiritual idea: When your mind is truly focused on something, you connect **everything** to it. The Chachamim told us that techelet (blue thread on tzitzit) reminds us of the sea, which reminds us of heaven — because when you live with awareness of Hashem, everything traces back to Him.

Echad Mi Yodea demonstrates: after an evening immersed in the Exodus, throw out any number — 1 through 13 — and we make a Jewish connection to it. This shows the evening has penetrated our consciousness. Every number, every concept, connects back to our faith and our story.

Summary: The Seder at a Glance

Step	Key Points
Kaddesh	Everyone drinks ~86 ml. Lean. Red wine/grape juice. Sephardim: bracha on 1st and 3rd cups only. Shehecheyanu covers all mitzvot of the night.
Urchatz	Wash without bracha. Year-round halacha for Sephardim (dipping vegetable in liquid).
Karpas	Small amount (< ke-zayit). Dip in salt water. Don't lean. Bracha covers until Maror.
Yachatz	Break middle matzah. Bigger piece = Afikoman. Smaller piece back under top matzah.
Maggid	Question and answer. Understand, don't just read. Use English if needed. Minimum: Mah Nishtanah, Avadim Hayinu, Rabban Gamliel, Hallel. Must be after nightfall.
Rachtzah	Wash with bracha (like regular bread).
Motzi Matzah	Leader: two ke-zeitim (top + middle). Everyone else: one ke-zayit (18–27g). Lean. Don't speak until after Korech. Eat within ~5 minutes.
Maror	One ke-zayit. Dip in charoset then shake off. Don't lean.
Korech	Sandwich. May keep charoset on. Lean.
Shulchan Orech	Enjoy the meal. Egg: follow your custom, doesn't matter when.
Tzafun	Afikoman: one ke-zayit. Before midnight (1:01 AM this year). Lean. No food after.
Barech	Birkat HaMazon — Torah obligation. Give it attention.
Hallel	Say together in unison. Pour 4th cup. Bracha on 3rd cup covers 4th (Sephardim).
Nirtzah	Songs. Every number connects to Judaism — proof the evening penetrated our hearts.

The Absolute Bare Minimum

If time, energy, or circumstances are severely limited:

1. **Kiddush** (first cup)
2. **Tell the story** — even briefly, even one paragraph, even in English — to your child
3. **Eat a ke-zayit of matzah**

These are the biblical core of the night.

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